

# Can Blood Vessel Networks in Ultrafast Breast MRI Predict Breast Cancer Treatment Response?

Predicting contrast changes improved the GNN, but it may also  
be learning differences in scan timing

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# Can vessel networks help personalize treatment?

## THE TREATMENT

Neoadjuvant therapy is given before surgery to shrink the tumor.

## THE OUTCOME

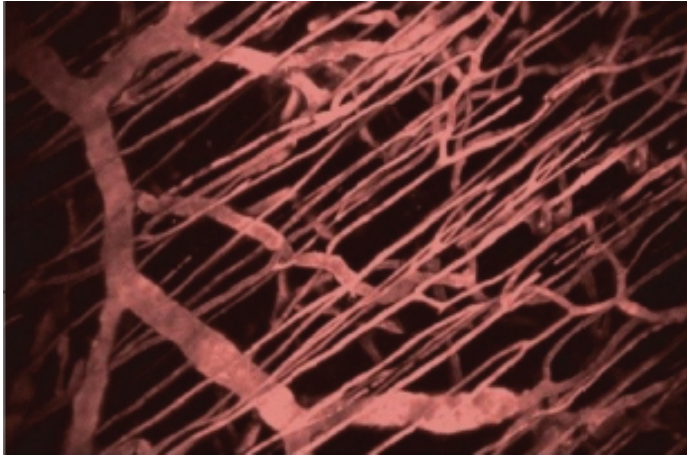
About 1 in 3 exams came from patients who achieved a pathologic complete response (**pCR**): no invasive cancer remained in the breast or nearby lymph nodes at surgery.

## THE QUESTION

Can a GNN use connections within breast vessel networks to improve treatment-response prediction?

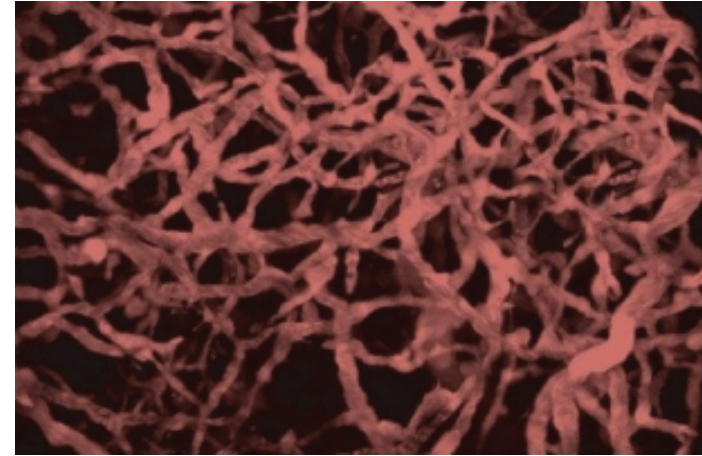
Earlier prediction could guide less intensive therapy for patients likely to achieve pCR and alternative therapy for those unlikely to do so.

# Tumors build a messier blood supply



## **Normal vessels: organized, efficient.**

Blood flows through a predictable, well-structured network.

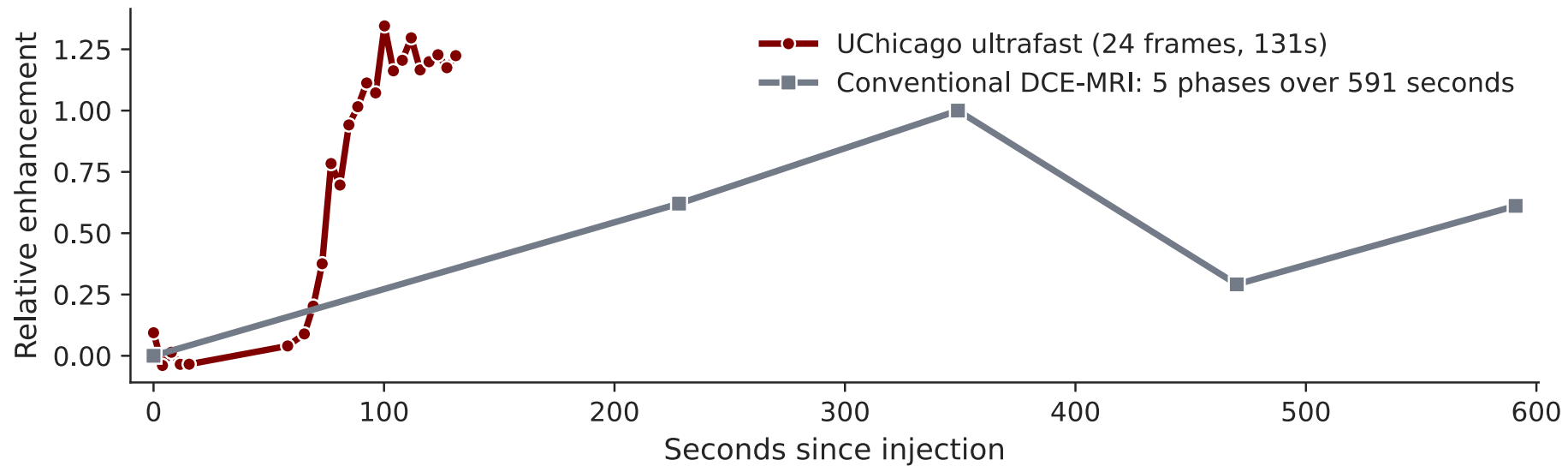


## **Tumor vessels: dense, tortuous, leaky.**

Tumors stimulate abnormal vessel growth as they grow. Structure may reflect how aggressive a tumor is.

Because tumor vessels differ in both structure and blood flow, those patterns may help predict treatment response.

# Ultrafast MRI movie shows more than anatomy



Curves are from different patients and are shown only to compare temporal sampling.

**179**

exams with known  
outcomes

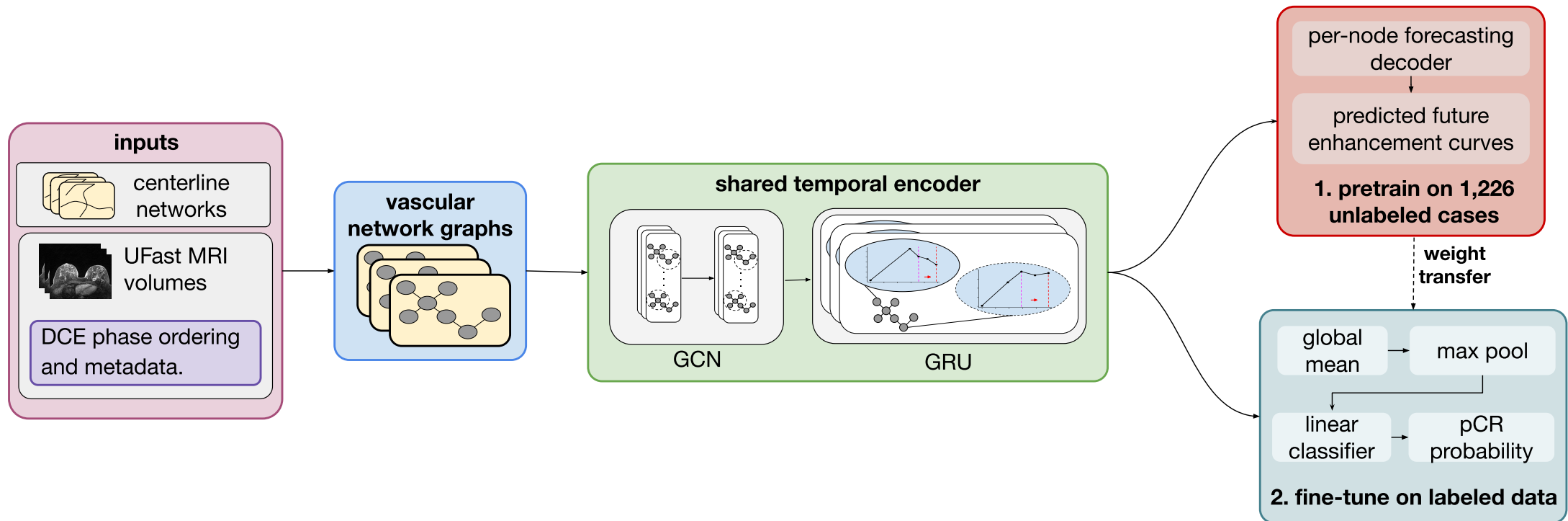
**1,226**

additional exams without outcome labels, used to teach the  
model how contrast changes over time

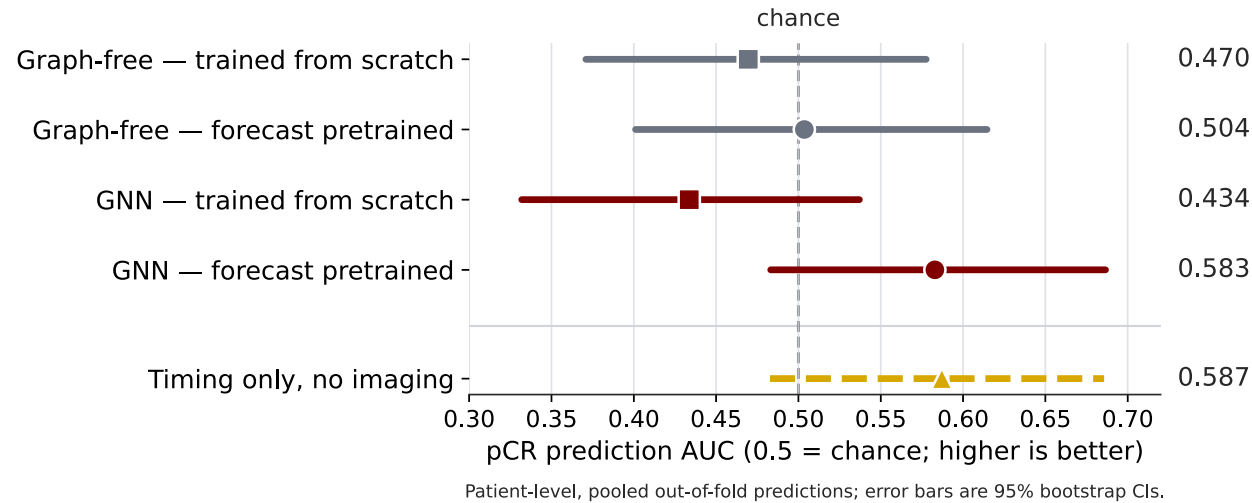
**13–24**

frames per ultrafast movie

# Does the graph structure help? How about pretraining?



# Learning to predict later MRI frames improved the GNN



## Pretraining helped.

Learning to predict later MRI frames improved the GNN by **0.149 AUC** (95% CI, 0.046–0.255). After pretraining, the GNN also outperformed the matched graph-free model by **0.079** (95% CI, 0.010–0.155).

## But scan timing was associated with pCR too.

A model using only scan-timing information, no imaging, reached **AUC 0.587** (95% CI, 0.483–0.686), and its predictions correlated with the GNN's at  **$r = 0.50$** . We don't yet know why; next we need to determine what drives that association and whether it influences the GNN's predictions.

# What should you remember?

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1

Learning to predict later MRI frames improved the **GNN**, which then outperformed the matched graph-free model.

2

Enhancement measurements without vessel connections **remained near chance.**

3

How the scans were timed also predicted pCR, so we need to learn whether the model is detecting **tumor biology or scan differences.**

**Learning to predict contrast changes improved the GNN, but some of its signal may come from how the scans were collected.**

# Thank you

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Questions welcome.

## Code

[github.com/dsi-clinic/vanguard](https://github.com/dsi-clinic/vanguard)

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